

THE ALPHABET, HAND TO HAND

Rows run in the transmission order (the shared abgad sequence + Greek post-tau additions), so each column reads top-to-bottom in its own alphabet's order. Classical Latin shows the alphabet at the turn of the millennium: the original slot-7 Z is gone (dropped ~3rd c. BCE), G holds that seat, and re-imported Y and Z sit at the end. Later Latin gives the modern letter with its main sound-developments across Europe (Romance + English). Greek-only letters (Θ Ξ Μ Φ Ψ Ω) drop into their Greek positions; faded cells mark ancestors or re-imports that don't count for the ordering.

/a/ sound changed      /a/ held      ƀ faded = doesn't count for order      𐤀 Greek-only, no Latin heir

| SOURCE WORD<br>PROTO-SINAITIC · HEBREW<br>· ~1800 BCE | PHOENICIAN<br>~1050 BCE | GREEK<br>~800 BCE | ETRUSCAN<br>~700 BCE | CLASSICAL LATIN<br>~ AD 1 | LATER LATIN<br>MODERN LETTER · SOUND IN EUROPE | SHIFTS & NOTES                                                                                                                                                                        | MODERN GREEK<br>TODAY · VS ANCIENT      |
|-------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------|-------------------|----------------------|---------------------------|------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------|
| ʔalp · ox<br>𐤀𐤋 elef thousand                         | 𐤀<br>/ʔ/                | Α<br>/a/          | 𐤁<br>/a/             | Α<br>/a/                  | Α<br>Eng. name /eɪ/ (GVS)                      | Consonant → vowel: Greek reheard the glottal stop as /a/. (Ox sense survives in <i>aluf</i> , 'chief'.)                                                                               | Α α<br>/a/<br>álfa                      |
| bayt · house<br>בַּיִת bayit house                    | 𐤁<br>/b/                | Β<br>/b/          | 𐤅<br>—<br>unused     | Β<br>/b/                  | Β<br>W. Rom. b→v/v/; Sp. b=v                   | Etruscan carried B in its abecedarium but never used it (no /b/); Latin reactivated it.                                                                                               | Β β<br>/v/<br>víta                      |
| gaml · camel<br>גָּמַל gamal camel                    | 𐤂<br>/g/                | Γ<br>/g/          | 𐤆<br>/k/             | ϸ<br>/k/                  | ϸ<br>palat.: It./tʃ/·Fr./s/·Sp./θ/             | Voicing lost at Etruscan (/g/→/k/); early C also spelled /g/ — that job passed to G.                                                                                                  | Γ γ<br>/ɣ/<br>gámma                     |
| dalt · door<br>דֶּלֶת delet door                      | 𐤃<br>/d/                | Δ<br>/d/          | 𐤄<br>—<br>unused     | Δ<br>/d/                  | Δ<br>Sp. intervoc. →[ð]                        | Carried but unused in Etruscan (no /d/); reactivated in Latin.                                                                                                                        | Δ δ<br>/ð/<br>délta                     |
| — uncertain<br>הֵה he name only                       | 𐤄<br>/h/                | Ε<br>/e/          | 𐤅<br>/e/             | Ε<br>/e/                  | Ε<br>Eng.→/i:/ (GVS)                           | Consonant → vowel at Greek (/h/ → /e/). The name <i>he</i> is no living noun; its picture is unknown.                                                                                 | Ε ε<br>/e/<br>épsilon                   |
| waw · hook<br>וָו vav hook                            | 𐤅<br>/w/                | Ϝ<br>/w/          | 𐤆<br>/w/             | Ϝ<br>/ɸ/                  | Ϝ<br>Sp. f→h- (hijo)                           | Digamma kept waw's /w/; Etruscan wrote /f/ as ϜϚ. <b>Latin reassigned</b> the shape to /f/ once V (← upsilon) took /w/.                                                               | —<br>digamma dropped ·<br>numeral Ϛ = 6 |
| zayin · weapon<br>זָיִן zayin weapon                  | 𐤆<br>/z/                | Ζ<br>/zd/         | 𐤇<br>/ts/            | —<br>dropped ~312 BCE     | —                                              | <b>Latin's two Z's</b> : at slot 7 in the Phoenician–Greek order. Dropped from Latin ~3rd c. BCE (rhotacism /z/→/r/); G took its seat; re-imported to the end 1st c. BCE (row below). | Ζ ζ<br>/z/<br>zíta                      |
| gaml · camel<br>גָּמַל gamal (via C)                  | 𐤂<br>/g/                | Γ<br>/g/          | 𐤆<br>/k/             | ϸ<br>/g/                  | ϸ<br>palat.: It./dʒ/·Fr./ʒ/·Sp./x/             | <b>New sign, c. 230 BCE</b> : a bar added to C to restore the /g/ Etruscan had erased — into the 7th seat Z vacated.                                                                  | Γ γ<br>/ɣ/<br>gámma                     |
| het · fence?<br>הֶת het name only                     | 𐤄<br>/h/                | Η<br>/h/ · /ɛ:/   | 𐤅<br>/h/             | Η<br>/h/                  | Η<br>silent across Romance                     | Phoenician het merges /h/+/x/. Greek <b>forks</b> : Western heta /h/ vs Ionic eta /ɛ:/; Latin took the Western /h/ branch.                                                            | Η η<br>/i/<br>íta                       |
| tet · wheel?<br>טֶת tet name only                     | 𐤈<br>/tˤ/               | Θ<br>/tʰ/         | 𐤉<br>/tʰ/            | —<br>→ TH                 | —                                              | Phoenician emphatic <b>tet</b> → Greek aspirate theta /tʰ/. Latin had no letter and wrote Greek θ as the digraph <b>TH</b> . Modern Greek fricativized it to /θ/.                     | Θ θ<br>/θ/<br>thíta                     |
| yad · hand<br>יָד yad hand                            | 𐤍<br>/j/                | Ι<br>/i/          | 𐤎<br>/i/             | Ι<br>/i/                  | Ι<br>Eng.→/aɪ/ (GVS); cons.→J                  | Consonant → vowel at Greek (/j/ → /i/); Latin used it for both /i/ and /j/ — the /j/ half later split off as J.                                                                       | Ι ι<br>/i/<br>ióta                      |
| yad · hand<br>יָד yad (via I)                         | —                       | —                 | —                    | —<br>= I                  | Ј<br>/dʒ/ · /ʒ/ · /x/ · /j/                    | <b>Youngest letter</b> : a 16th-c. swash split from I to carry the consonant /j/ → /dʒ/. Absent at 0 AD.                                                                              | Ι ι<br>/i/<br>ióta                      |
| kap · palm<br>כַּף kaf palm                           | 𐤌<br>/k/                | Κ<br>/k/          | 𐤍<br>/k/             | Κ<br>/k/                  | Κ<br>stable /k/                                | Etruscan used K before /a/ — part of a three-way C / K / Q split by following vowel that Latin inherited.                                                                             | Κ κ<br>/k/<br>káppa                     |
| lamd · goad<br>לָמַד lamed 'to learn'                 | 𐤌<br>/l/                | Λ<br>/l/          | 𐤎<br>/l/             | Λ<br>/l/                  | Λ<br>Sp. -ll→/ʎ/→/j/                           | <i>Stable throughout.</i>                                                                                                                                                             | Λ λ<br>/l/<br>lámda                     |
| maym · water<br>מַיִם mayim water                     | 𐤍<br>/m/                | Μ<br>/m/          | 𐤏<br>/m/             | Μ<br>/m/                  | Μ<br>stable                                    | <i>Stable throughout.</i>                                                                                                                                                             | Μ μ<br>/m/<br>mí                        |
| nun · fish<br>נִין nun fish = dag                     | 𐤎<br>/n/                | Ν<br>/n/          | 𐤏<br>/n/             | Ν<br>/n/                  | Ν<br>-gn→/ɲ/ (ñ)                               | <i>Stable throughout.</i> ('Fish' is the Aramaic sense; Hebrew for fish is <i>dag</i> .)                                                                                              | Ν ν<br>/n/<br>nī                        |

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| samek · prop<br>𐤌 samekh <i>support</i>               | 𐤌<br>/s/                | Ξ<br>/ks/         | —                    | —<br>→ X                  | —                                              | Samekh took the 14th slot, repurposed by Greek for /ks/. Latin got /ks/ from Western <b>chi</b> → <b>X</b> , so xi itself left no Latin heir.                                                      | Ξ ξ<br>/ks/<br>ksi                     |
| ʿayn · eye<br>𐤀 ayin <i>eye</i>                       | 𐤀<br>/ʿ/                | Ο<br>/o/          | 𐤀<br>—<br>unused     | Ο<br>/o/                  | Ο<br>Eng.→/oo/ (GVS)                           | Phoenician ayin merges /ʿ/ + /g/. Consonant → vowel at Greek. Etruscan had no /o/ (unused); Latin reactivated it.                                                                                  | Ο ο<br>/o/<br>ómikron                  |
| pe · mouth<br>𐤐 pe <i>mouth</i>                       | 𐤐<br>/p/                | Π<br>/p/          | 𐤐<br>/p/             | P<br>/p/                  | P<br>W. Rom. p→b→v                             | <i>Stable throughout.</i>                                                                                                                                                                          | Π π<br>/p/<br>pi                       |
| šade · fish-hook?<br>𐤑 tsade <i>name only</i>         | 𐤑<br>/sʕ/               | Μ<br>/s/          | —                    | —<br>→ S                  | —                                              | Phoenician emphatic <b>šade</b> → Greek <b>san</b> (Μ). Sigma won; san died before the classical age. No Latin heir — /s/ reached Latin via sigma → S. Afterlife: numeral 𐤑 (sampi, 900), debated. | —<br>obsolete · sampi 𐤑 = 900?         |
| — uncertain<br>𐤒 qof <i>monkey (mod.)</i>             | 𐤒<br>/q/                | Ϟ<br>/k/          | 𐤒<br>/k/             | Q<br>/k/                  | Q<br>/kw/→/k/ (que)                            | Qoppa, before back vowels; dropped from classical Greek (numeral 90). Latin keeps Q only in QV.                                                                                                    | —<br>koppa dropped ·<br>numeral 𐤒 = 90 |
| raʾš · head<br>𐤓 rosh <i>head</i>                     | 𐤓<br>/ɾ/                | P<br>/ɾ/          | 𐤓<br>/ɾ/             | R<br>/ɾ/                  | R<br>Fr.→ uvular /ʁ/                           | Sound stable; Latin added the diagonal leg to tell R apart from P.                                                                                                                                 | P ϱ<br>/ɾ/<br>zo                       |
| šin · tooth<br>𐤔 shen <i>tooth</i>                    | 𐤔<br>/ʃ/                | Σ<br>/s/          | 𐤔<br>/s/             | S<br>/s/                  | S<br>Fr. drops pre-cons.; Sp. e-               | Sibilant shuffle: shin's /ʃ/ became sigma's /s/ (and swapped names with samek).                                                                                                                    | Σ σ/ς<br>/s/<br>sigma                  |
| taw · mark<br>𐤕 tav <i>mark, sign</i>                 | 𐤕<br>/t/                | T<br>/t/          | 𐤕<br>/t/             | T<br>/t/                  | T<br>-ti-→/ts/→/s/ (nation)                    | <i>Stable throughout.</i>                                                                                                                                                                          | T τ<br>/t/<br>taf                      |
| waw · hook<br>𐤖 vav <i>(via Y)</i>                    | 𐤖<br>/w/                | Υ<br>/u/          | 𐤖<br>/u/             | —<br>= V                  | U<br>Eng.→/ju:/                                | Upsilon — waw's second child, appended at the Greek alphabet's end as vowel /u/. U split from V in the late Middle Ages. Absent at 0 AD.                                                           | Υ υ<br>/i/<br>ipsilon                  |
| waw · hook<br>𐤖 vav <i>(via Y)</i>                    | 𐤖<br>/w/                | Υ<br>/u/          | 𐤖<br>/u, w/          | V<br>/w, u/               | V<br>Lat./w/→/v/; Sp. v=b                      | Same upsilon line; in Latin, V served both /w/ and /u/. The whole U · V · W · Y clan descends from this one sign.                                                                                  | Υ υ<br>/i/<br>ipsilon                  |
| waw · hook<br>𐤖 vav <i>(via V)</i>                    | —                       | —                 | —                    | —<br>= V                  | W<br>Eng./w/ · Ger./v/                         | <b>Doubled V</b> — a medieval invention for a Germanic /w/ that Latin had no letter for. Absent at 0 AD.                                                                                           | Υ υ<br>/i/<br>ipsilon                  |
| — <i>Greek invention</i>                              | —                       | Φ<br>/pʰ/         | 𐤗<br>/pʰ/            | —<br>→ PH                 | —                                              | A <b>Greek invention</b> (with Ψ, X) for aspirated /pʰ/ — no Phoenician parent. Latin wrote it <b>PH</b> ; Modern Greek turned it into /f/.                                                        | Φ φ<br>/ɸ/<br>fi                       |
| samek · prop<br>𐤗 samekh <i>(via X)</i>               | —                       | X<br>/ks/         | 𐤗<br>/ks/            | X<br>/ks/                 | X<br>Sp.→/x/~/s/ (México)                      | A Greek supplemental with no Phoenician parent. Latin took the <b>Western</b> value /ks/; Eastern Greek used X for /kʰ/. Ends the classical alphabet before Y, Z.                                  | X χ<br>/x/<br>chi · /ks/ = Ξ           |
| waw · hook<br>𐤖 vav <i>(via Y)</i>                    | 𐤖<br>/w/                | Υ<br>/y/          | —                    | Y<br>/y/                  | Y<br>Gk /y/ (ü) → /i/                          | Re-borrowed straight from Greek upsilon in the 1st c. BCE for Greek loanwords — bypassing Etruscan; the ‘Greek i’. (Upsilon faded — already solid at U/V.)                                         | Υ υ<br>/i/<br>ipsilon                  |
| — <i>Greek invention</i>                              | —                       | Ψ<br>/ps/         | —                    | —<br>→ PS                 | —                                              | A <b>Greek invention</b> for /ps/ (Eastern value; Western Greek used the shape for /kʰ/). No Latin letter — written <b>PS</b> . Stable today.                                                      | Ψ ψ<br>/ps/<br>psi                     |
| — <i>Ionian, ‹ O</i>                                  | —                       | Ω<br>/ɔ:/         | —                    | —<br>→ 0                  | —                                              | The last Greek letter — an <b>Ionian addition</b> (~7th–6th c. BCE), a long-/ɔ:/ twin of omicron. Latin used <b>O</b> . Modern Greek merged it back to plain /o/.                                  | Ω ω<br>/o/<br>oméga                    |
| ‹ zayin (row 7)                                       | —                       | Z<br>/z/          | —                    | Z<br>/z/                  | Z<br>It./ts/ · Sp./θ/ (zapato)                 | Latin's re-import of Z (1st c. BCE) sits at the alphabet's <b>end</b> — its ancestral 7th seat had gone to G. Its Phoenician–Greek ancestry is in the slot-7 row above.                            | —                                      |

On the **glyphs**. Unicode's canonical reference forms, not the variable shapes actually inscribed; Etruscan ran right-to-left, and Classical Latin had no lowercase (I and V each did double duty until J, U, W split off in the Middle Ages). The Later-Latin column is a headline sketch — Romance outcomes vary by language and position. Source words and several values are reconstructed and debated (E, H, Q, 𐤒et, šade). Digamma (F), koppa (Q) and san (𐤌) survive in Greek only as numerals or not at all.